English Today — B1

Unit 3: Food and Restaurants

Reading: A Busy Saturday at The Copper Kettle

The Copper Kettle is a small family restaurant near the river in the town of Elmbridge. Marta Lewis opened it twelve years ago, and she still cooks every lunch herself.

On Saturdays the restaurant is always full. Marta starts work at seven o'clock in the morning. First she bakes bread, and then she prepares the soup of the day. Her son Leo works as a waiter.
He sets the tables, writes the specials on the blackboard and greets the first customers at twelve o'clock.

Last Saturday was especially busy. A group of fifteen tourists arrived without a booking, and Leo had to join four tables together. There wasn't any fresh fish left, so Marta changed the menu and offered a vegetable pie instead. The tourists loved it. One of them, Mr Okafor, asked for the recipe!

At the end of the day Leo counted the bill payments. "We have served more meals today than ever
before," he said. Marta smiled, sat down and finally had a cup of tea.

Vocabulary

booking (n)

- An arrangement to have a table at a certain time
- We made a booking for eight people.

Specials

- dishes that are on the menu only today
- The specials are written on the blackboard.

Starter

- a small dish you eat before the main course
- I'd like the soup as a starter.

main course

- the biggest dish of a meal

- For the main course she ordered vegetable pie.

Bill
- the paper that shows how much you have to pay
- Could we have the bill, please?

Tip
- extra money you give a waiter for good service
- They left a generous tip.

Recipe
- instructions for cooking a dish
- Mr Okafor asked for the recipe.

Greet
- to say hello to someone when they arrive
- Leo greets every customer at the door.

Serve
- to give food or drink to customers
- The restaurant serves lunch until three. |

Grammar: Countable and uncountable nouns with *some* and *any*

Countable nouns have a plural form: *a table – two tables, an egg – three eggs*.
Uncountable nouns have no plural form: *bread, soup, fish, tea, money*.

- Use some in positive sentences: *There is some soup. There are some tables free.*
- Use any in negative sentences and questions: *There isn't any fresh fish. Are there any free tables?*
- Use some in offers and requests: *Would you like some tea? Can I have some bread?*

Useful phrases in a restaurant

- "I'd like to book a table for two, please."
- "Could we see the menu, please?"
- "What are today's specials?"
- "I'll have the vegetable pie, please."
- "Could we have the bill, please?"

Exercises

1. True or false?

1. Marta opened The Copper Kettle twelve years ago.
2. Leo is the cook.
3. The tourists had a booking.
4. There was no fresh fish left last Saturday.
5. Mr Okafor asked for the recipe of the vegetable pie.

2. Complete with *some* or *any*.

1. Is there ___ soup left?
2. We need ___ bread for the tables.
3. There aren't ___ free tables tonight.
4. Would you like ___ tea?

3. Put the words in order.

1. table / a / I'd / to / book / like / for two
2. have / we / the / could / bill / please
3. are / specials / what / today's